

Women's heart disease studies suggest lowering BP thresholds ~10 mmHg below men's. The SPRINT sex-specific analysis (Foy et al., *J Hypertens* 2018) showed no heterogeneity by sex with SBP targets <120 vs <140 for all ¹ – it did not set separate female cutoffs. In contrast, recent cohort analyses find women's CVD risk rises at substantially lower SBP. Ji et al. (*Circulation* 2021) report that incident CVD appeared in women at SBP 100–109 mmHg versus 130–139 in men ². In their data, female SBP 100–109 produced an adjusted CVD hazard ratio ~1.25, comparable to the 1.26 seen in men at 130–139 (so women at ~105 mmHg equaled men at 130). Likewise, MI risk emerged at 110–119 in women vs ≥160 in men, and HF/stroke risks at 110–119 or 120–129 in women versus much higher SBP in men ³. A review similarly notes that BP-linked ACS/HF risk begins ~10 mmHg lower in women, and that “high-normal” SBP (130–139) doubles MI risk in midlife women but not men ⁴. Thus women's BP zones should be shifted downward by ≈10 mmHg. For example, if men's normal SBP is 120–129, then women's normal would be ~110–119; women's “high” (hypertension) would begin ~130 instead of 140. In practice this implies treating a woman with SBP ≈125 (vs a man at 135) as similarly “borderline” or high. In Ji's data, women at ~105 mmHg had CVD risk equal to men at 130 ². Based on these findings, we propose the table below.

Zone	Male SBP (mmHg)	Female SBP (mmHg)
Optimal	<120	<110
Normal	120–129	110–119
Borderline	130–139	120–129
High	≥140	≥130

Table: Sex-specific SBP categories. These are adjusted ~10 mmHg lower for women based on sex-stratified risk data ² ⁴.

References (DOIs): Foy et al. (SPRINT, *J Hypertens* 2018) ¹; Ji et al. “Sex Differences in BP...Cardiovascular Outcomes” (*Circulation* 2021) ²; Gerds & de Simone “Hypertension in Women...” (*Eur Cardiol Rev* 2021) ⁴; Cho et al. “Arterial Hypertension in Women” (*Hypertension* 2023).

¹ Gender, blood pressure, and cardiovascular and renal outcomes in adults with hypertension from the Systolic Blood Pressure Intervention Trial | Request PDF

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² ³ (PDF) Sex Differences in Blood Pressure Associations With Cardiovascular Outcomes

https://www.researchgate.net/publication/349348420_Sex_Differences_in_Blood_Pressure_Associations_With_Cardiovascular_Outcomes

349348420_Sex_Differences_in_Blood_Pressure_Associations_With_Cardiovascular_Outcomes

⁴ (PDF) Hypertension in Women: Should There be a Sex-specific Threshold?

https://www.researchgate.net/publication/355415000_Hypertension_in_Women_Should_There_be_a_Sex-specific_Threshold